How to Dramatically Reduce Parenting Stress.

What modern parenting never gave you the chance to discover, until now.

GEOFF OWEN — FOUNDER, BIOLOGICALLY ALIGNED PARENTING

The stress you seldom talk about

There is a particular kind of exhaustion that high-performing parents carry and almost never mention. And for good reason. Often, they are very confused by it. It is not the kind of exhaustion that comes from work. That is something else entirely. It is the exhaustion of coming home after a long, hard day and finding that the part of your life that should feel the most natural and enjoyable actually feels like the hardest thing you do all day.

If you have ever spoken to your child in a way you later regretted, or felt disengaged when you were supposed to be fully present, or gone through the motions of an evening without really being there, you are not alone. What is more likely going on is that you are following a way of being as a parent that bypasses your child's biology entirely.

Where this actually comes from

Before I explain what I mean by that, I want to tell you something about my own family, because it matters to what follows.

My wife and I never used discipline. Not consequences, not naughty steps, not sending our children to their rooms, not grounding them, not taking things away to control their behaviour. None of it. Not because we were unusually patient or gentle. It simply was not needed, once we followed our children's biology instead of managing their behaviour.

I want to be precise about what “modern parenting” actually is, because it is rarely named honestly. Naughty steps. Reward charts. Time-outs. Consequences. Grounding. Taking privileges away. These are not neutral tools. They are behaviourist conditioning, the same basic mechanism B.F. Skinner demonstrated with rats and pigeons: reward the behaviour you want, punish the behaviour you don't, and shape the outcome through pressure. It is the same system used in prisons. The same system used in most schools. And, to a real degree, the same system used in business.

It works, in the narrow sense that you can shape behaviour with enough pressure and enough reward. But it was never designed for a relationship. It was designed for control. And it never addresses why the behaviour is there in the first place.

What most parents do

When you get into a situation with your child that is not working, it is a natural instinct to apply more. More time, more consistency, more patience, more structure. Just more. Or maybe you are less proactive than that, and you simply carry the weight of not really knowing what to do or where to turn.

Either way, there is an assumption sitting beneath all of it. That the problem is effort, or time. If only you had more of either, things would improve.

They will not. It is not because you are not trying hard enough. It is the approach you are following.

What that approach actually produces

The more you try, the more effort you put in, the more time you spend, the more likely you are to produce more of the same result. More conflict, more exhaustion, more guilt, and that quiet, crushing feeling where your inner critic tells you that you are failing at the one thing that matters most to you, being in right relationship with your children.

The harder you try to manage your child's behaviour, because that is what modern parenting actually is, a management process, the more you find yourself repeating the same boundaries and the same consequences, over and over, with diminishing return.

This is not a character failing. It is a problem with the framework itself.

Sixty-five per cent of working parents report burnout, according to a peer-reviewed study in the Journal of Pediatric Health Care, 2025. Forty-six per cent of fathers say they do not spend enough time with their children, according to Pew Research. And executives, when asked about the gap between who they are at home and who they are at work, described becoming visibly emotional simply at being asked the question, according to Time magazine's research with thirty-five senior leaders.

You are not unusual. You simply have not been given the right map.

What is actually happening

Your child is not behaving badly. Their behaviour is not a problem to be solved. It is something to be understood.

Children are not blank slates waiting to be managed, as modern parenting would have it. They are born with a precise biological blueprint, entirely unconscious, designed to receive what it needs from the humans around it. It reads the environment constantly, through every sense, asking, without words or thought, whether what it needs is actually there. When those needs are met, children are more cooperative, and far easier to be with.

Think of a fire alarm. If you put a blanket over it, the noise quietens. But the fire is still burning. That is modern parenting's relationship to difficult behaviour, so concerned with the noise that it never looks for the fire. Left unaddressed, that fire will build, and it can rage into an inferno.

When a child's needs go unmet, the body responds in one of two ways. It tries to correct the gap and get what is missing. Or it tries to get relief from the discomfort of the gap staying unmet. That is what shows up as disrespect, opposition, defiance, or withdrawal. We call it naughtiness. It is not naughtiness. It is biology.

Modern parenting's idea of love

Modern parenting has its own idea of what love looks like. Buying things. Doing things for them, removing struggle before they even feel it. Praising achievement and performance. Shielding them from any disappointment. Constant reassurance and validation. Consulting them like a peer on decisions that were never theirs to make. Avoiding conflict to keep them happy. Filling their time with enriching activities and calling it investment. Calling constant guidance “support” and steady praise “confidence-building.”

None of that is really love, in the sense that changes anything. As Gordon Neufeld puts it:

“It's not the love a parent has for the child that makes them easier to parent, but the love the child has for the parent.”

And a child's love for their parent grows from one thing: their biology being honoured. Closeness. Calm, consistent presence. Confident leadership. Being trusted with real responsibility. Not something you give them. Something you simply are, with them.

What actually needs to happen

It is not about the time. It was never about the time. It is about what you are not providing when you are there, even on the days you cannot be there as much as you would like. And this is the genuinely good news: it is not a burden of effort. It is not about trying harder. It is about understanding what your child's biology actually requires, and what happens in the gap when that goes unmet.

What I teach is a way to precisely read a child's behaviour. Not manage it. Not suppress it. Read it. However unwanted or difficult it looks in the moment, it is always pointing to something your child needs, unconsciously, innately, that is missing from their environment right now.

When parents can do that, something fundamental shifts. They stop seeing the behaviour as the problem and start seeing it as a signal. And that shift, from problem to signal, tends to bring something parents rarely expect: they feel more in control without being controlling. Not because they are exerting more, but because they finally know what their child's behaviour actually means.

Modern parenting's answer to almost everything is more. More reading. More journaling. More tips and more tricks. More consistency, more structure, more scripts for what to say in the moment, another new strategy to try when the last one stops working. It keeps asking you to add, and then add again, and it rarely tells you when enough is enough, because it was never actually addressing the cause.

Biologically Aligned Parenting asks for the opposite. Not more, but less. Less effort. Less time spent managing. Less energy spent staying consistent with strategies that only ever manage the surface. What follows tends to be something genuinely different: a home where cooperation comes more easily, where difficult moments pass without escalating into something bigger, and where you finally have a way of understanding what is actually happening in front of you, rather than just reacting to it. Effortless, not because nothing is happening, but because you are finally working with your child's biology instead of against it.

A conversation, if it would help

Thank you for reading this far. If any of this resonates, or you'd like to talk through what it actually looks like for your own family, I offer a free, forty-five minute conversation, no obligation, no pitch. You're welcome to book a time that suits you.

BOOK A CONVERSATION →

Geoff Owen · Founder, Biologically Aligned Parenting · geoffreyowen.com

© 2026 Geoff Owen. All rights reserved.